Lesson 8 — The Line We Share

Part 11 of 12: Answer key and teacher notes

Level: B1 (eighth step)

About 10 minutes · this part carries a sheet

Listening: L1 — from a box on the third floor, up to an antenna on the roof and across to a second antenna on the roof opposite · L2 — the lesson is over for all thirty students, because nobody has a second way in · L3 — she downloads the slides, because the line is quiet and the latency is low · L4 — an exchange place at a university in Spain, with a small scholarship

Part A (MCQ): 1-C · 2-B · 3-D · 4-A · 5-C · 6-B · 7-B · 8-C · 9-C · 10-D

Why 7 is [B]: the sentence weighs the cost of preparing against the benefit, and only the paragraph after [B] does that — Sunday's download, the kept recordings, and the closing line that she has lost nothing but twenty minutes of a quiet Sunday. The paragraph after [A] explains the mesh, after [C] is the faster line she does not have, after [D]** the application.

Why 8 is C**: the paragraph opens by saying she is careful about the wish, because a wish is easy to turn into an excuse. The point is not the fifty megabits; it is the line she draws between what she cannot change and what she can.

Why 9 is C**: the technology is explained only as far as the story needs, the application is one paragraph of seven, and the rules about large uploads are reported, not argued for. The passage follows one person working around a shared constraint.

Why 10 is D, respectful: A is the trap. Pitying would be a reasonable guess from the subject matter, and it is wrong — pity would dwell on what is missing. This writer dwells on what is done: the plan, the rules, the second antenna, the tower put up twice. The one sentence that could invite pity, about apologising at the start of every call, is given as something she intends to stop, not as something to feel sorry about. Attitude questions reward reading the selection of detail**, not the subject.

Part B (True/False):

1. F — Seven families share one uplink through a mesh.
2. T
3. T
4. T
5. T
6. F — She will apply again in the spring.

Part C (Fill in the blanks): 1. uplink · 2. mesh · 3. tower · 4. latency · 5. reliable · 6. scholarship · 7. requirement (Extra words: antenna, relay)

2.4 A (Opposites): 1. unreliable · 2. be too expensive for · 3. withdraw · 4. keep to yourself · 5. an instant reply

2.4 B (Odd one out): 1. scholarship (the others are on or above a building) · 2. requirement (the others are parts of a network) · 3. neighbour (the others are properties of a connection)

Come back to (time clauses): 1. comes · 2. finishes · 3. drops · 4. load … will begin

3.6 A (first conditional): 1. fails … will be · 2. is … will go · 3. ignore … will know · 4. will send … does not happen

3.6 B (second conditional): 1. had … would stop · 2. were … would apply · 3. knew … would not need · 4. would … do … came

3.6 C (first or second, and why):

1. will stay — rain tomorrow is a real possibility
2. were … would buy — she is not rich; the past tense marks it as unreal
3. load … will start — a real possibility this evening
4. does not get … will apply — she may well not get it; it is real either way

3.6 D (unless): 1. Unless the uplink comes back, the class is over. · 2. Unless you tell them first, they will be annoyed.

3.6 E (time clauses): 1. drops · 2. passes · 3. sends

Mini-quiz: 1. present simple, will · 2. past simple, would · 3. No — it means distance from reality: the thing is not true, or is not expected · 4. if … not · 5. the present simple · 6. had, because gone is a past participle; 'd + bare verb is would, 'd + past participle is had · 7. unreliable · 8. latency · 9–12. teacher judgement

Teacher Notes

What changed from Lesson 7, and what deliberately did not. 516 words, against 510 in Lesson 7 and 504 in Lesson 6 — three lessons at one length, which was the point of the plateau. Over these three weeks the difficulty has moved entirely into the grammar and the vocabulary: the future, then the modals, now the conditionals, with the technical density climbing each time. The question set has not changed since Lesson 5 and will not change again.

The one real difficulty. Not the forms, which are two patterns on a card. It is understanding that the past tense in the second conditional is not past time. Arabic does not use a past form to mark unreality, so if she had a faster line reads to her as a sentence about last year. Section 3.3 is the one to work: both example sentences are about the future, and the only thing the tense tells you is how real the speaker thinks it is. Ask her, for each sentence in 3.6 C, does the speaker think this will happen? — the answer to that chooses the tense.

The rule everything rests on. The Come back to section is deliberately placed before the conditionals rather than after. I will call you when the power comes on and if the power comes on, I will call you are the same rule: the future is marked once, in the main clause, and the subordinate clause stays present. A student who has that rule finds the first conditional almost automatic; a student who has not will write if the uplink will fail for a year. Teach it first even if you run out of time for 3.5.

Why the pronunciation part is the one to protect. The whole second conditional hangs on one consonant, and that consonant is ambiguous: 'd is would and 'd is had. The test is mechanical — a bare verb after it means would, a past participle means had — and once she has it, a large amount of spoken English stops

being a guess. The weak if and the rising tune matter nearly as much: if she lets the if-clause fall, people will answer before she has finished the sentence.

Why this story, and a note on it. The passage touches her own situation — a shared line, a class that depends on it, an exchange application with a language requirement. That is on purpose, and so is the distance: the student in it is somebody else, the detail is practical rather than personal, and nothing in it is there to be felt sorry about. The conditionals need a real constraint to be about, because a conditional sentence is how a person reasons about what is and is not within reach, and that is exactly what this passage is doing.

Success criteria for Lesson 8. The student should be able to:

- answer L1–L4 correctly on the second hearing;
- hear she'd gone and she'd go and say which is which, and why;
- build both conditionals and choose between them for a reason she can state;
- use the present simple after if, when, until, as soon as and before;
- write if I were, not if I was;
- rewrite an if … not sentence with unless;
- use 10 of the 14 key words in her own sentence;
- write 14 sentences with fewer than 4 conditional errors.

If it is too easy: add the third conditional (if she had applied, she would have gone) and the mixed conditional, both of which follow naturally from the 'd work in part 05. If it is too hard: teach the first conditional alone this week, with the time-clause rule, and leave the second for a week of its own. The second conditional is the harder idea by a long way, and splitting them costs nothing.

A note on spaced recall. `03-vocabulary.mp3` ends with five Lesson 6 words — download, cloud, schedule, laptop, socket. Lesson 7 recalled Lesson 5, so the two-lesson gap holds. Lesson 7's words are due back in Lesson 9.

Where the course is now. Eight lessons, one progress test, a complete TOEFL question set and eight tenses or structures, all spiralled at least twice. The length has been flat for three lessons, which means the next decision is whether Lesson 9 lets it rise again or holds it a fourth time — that is a question about her, not about the material, and the self-report at 6.3 is where the answer should come from. A second progress test, covering Lessons 4 to 8, would fit naturally before Lesson 9.